Los Vendidos (The Sellouts)

By Luis Valdez

HONEST SANCHO's Used Mexican Lot and Mexican Curio Shop. Three models are on display in HONEST SANCHO 's shop. HONEST SANCHO is moving among his models, dusting them off and preparing for another day of business.

SANCHO: **(Pg 40-52)** Bueno, bueno, mis monos, vamos a ver a quién vendemos ahora, ¿no? (*Well, well, my monkeys, let's see who we sell to now, right?)* (To audience.) I'm Honest Sancho and this is my shop. All I need now is a customer. (woman enters) Ay, a customer!

SECRETARY: Good morning, I'm Miss Jimenez from. . .

SANCHO: Ah, una chicana! Welcome, welcome Señorita Jiménez.

SECRETARY: (Anglo pronunciation.) JIM-enez. My name is Miss JIM-enez. Don't you speak English? What's wrong with you?

SANCHO: Oh, nothing, Señorita JIM-enez. I'm here to help you.

SECRETARY: That's better. As I was starting to say, I'm a secretary from the Governor's office, and we're looking for a Mexican type for the administration.

SANCHO: Well, you come to the right place, lady. This is Honest Sancho's Used Mexican Lot, and we got all types here. Any particular type you want?

INTRODUCTION

Williams.

SANCHO: **. . .** Any particular type you want?

SECRETARY: Yes, we were looking for somebody suave … debonaire. Dark. But of course, not too dark. Perhaps, beige.

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SANCHO: Beige, just the tone.

SECRETARY: One more thing. He must be hard-working.

SANCHO: That could only be one model. Step right over here, lady. This is our standard farmworker model. Take special notice of his 4-ply Goodyear huaraches, made from the rain tire. This wide-brimmed sombrero is an extra added feature; keeps off the sun, rain and dust. And our farmworker model is friendly. Muy amable. Watch. (Snaps his fingers.)

FARMWORKER: (Lifts up head.) Buenos días, señorita. (His head drops.)

SANCHO: But his most attractive feature is that he's hardworking. Let me show you. (Snaps fingers. FARMWORKER stands.)

FARMWORKER: ¡El jale! (He begins to work.)

SANCHO: As you can see he is cutting grapes. He also picks cotton. (Snaps. FARMWORKER begins to pick cotton.) That's his slow speed for late in the season. Here's his fast speed. (Snap. FARMWORKER picks faster.)

SECRETARY: Chihuahua … I mean, goodness, he sure is a hard worker. But is he economical?

SANCHO: Economical? Señorita, you are looking at the Volkswagen of Mexicans. Pennies a day is all it takes. One plate of beans and tortillas will keep him going all day.

SECRETARY: What about storage?

SANCHO: No problem. You know these new farm labor camps? They were designed with our model in mind. Five, six, seven, even ten in one of those shacks will give you no trouble at all. And here's an added feature: every year at the end of the season, this model goes back to Mexico and doesn't return, automatically, until next Spring.

SECRETARY: How about that. But tell me, does he speak English?

SANCHO: Bueno … no, pero he has other features …

SECRETARY: No! He just won't do!

SANCHO: Okay, okay, pues. We have other models.

SECRETARY: I hope so. What we need is something a little more sophisticated. An urban model.

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SANCHO: Ah, from the city! Over here in this corner of the shop is exactly what you're looking for. Introducing our new 1969 JOHNNY PACHUCO model! Streamlined. Built for speed, low-riding, city life. Let me just turn him on. (Snap. JOHNNY walks to stage center with a PACHUCO bounce.)

SECRETARY: What was that?

SANCHO: That, señorita, was the Chicano shuffle.

SECRETARY: Okay, what does he do?

SANCHO: Anything and everything necessary for city life. For instance, survival: he knife fights. (Snaps. JOHNNY pulls out a switchblade and swings at SECRETARY. SECRETARY screams.)

SANCHO: And here's a feature no city model can be without. He gets arrested, but not without resisting, of course. (Snap.)

JOHNNY: En la madre, la placa. I didn't do it! I didn't do it! (JOHNNY turns and stands up against an imaginary wall, legs spread out, arms behind his back.)

SECRETARY: Oh no, we can't have arrests! We must maintain law and order.

SANCHO: But he's bilingual. He speaks English! He's economical. Nickels and dimes. You can keep Johnny running on hamburgers, Taco Bell tacos, Lucky Lager beer . . .

SECRETARY: Mr. Sancho, I don't think you quite understand what we need. What we need is something that will attract the women voters. Something more traditional.

SANCHO: Ah! (He smiles meaningfully.) Step right over here, señorita. Introducing our standard Revolucionario type. As you can see, he is well-built, sturdy, durable.

SECRETARY: What does he do?

SANCHO: You name it, he does it. He rides horses, stays in the mountains, crosses deserts, plains, rivers, leads revolutions, follows revolutions, kills, can be killed, serves as a martyr, hero, movie star. Listen to this. (Snap.)

REVOLUCIONARIO: (Scream.) ¡Viva Villaaaaa!

SECRETARY: That's awfully loud.

SANCHO: He has a volume control. (He adjusts volume. Snap.)

REVOLUCIONARIO: (Mousey voice.) Viva Villa.

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SANCHO: And even if you didn't see him in the movies, perhaps you saw him on TV. He makes commercials. (Snap.)

REVOLUCIONARIO: Is there a Frito Bandito in your house?

SECRETARY: Oh yes, I've seen that one!

SANCHO: And finally, there is one outstanding feature about this model I know the ladies are going to love: he's a genuine antique! He was made in Mexico in 1910!

SECRETARY: Made in Mexico? Mr. Sancho, I thought he was an American product. I'm sorry. We can't buy anything but American made products. We need Mexican models, such as these, but it's more important that he be American.

SANCHO: Wait a minute! Mexican but American? Mexican but … (A sudden flash.) American! Yeah, I think we've got exactly what you want. He just came in today! Give me a minute. (He exits and brings out the MEXICAN-AMERICAN model, a clean-shaven middle class type in a business suit, with glasses.) Introducing our new 1970 Mexican-American! Ta-ra-ra-raaaa!

SECRETARY: (Impressed.) Where have you been hiding this one?

SANCHO: He just came in this morning. Feast your eyes on him! Sturdy U.S. Steel frame, streamlined, modern. As a matter of fact, he is built exactly like our Anglo models, except that he comes in a variety of darker shades: naugahide, leather or leatherette.

SECRETARY: Naugahide.

SANCHO: Well, we'll just write that down. Yes, señorita, this model represents the apex of American engineering! He is bilingual, college educated, ambitious! He is intelligent, well-mannered, clean. Did I say clean? (Snap. MEXICANAMERICAN raises his arm.) Smell.

SECRETARY: (Smells.) Old Sobaco, my favorite.

SANCHO: (Snap. MEXICAN-AMERICAN turns toward SANCHO.) Eric? (To SECRETARY.) We call him Eric García. (To ERIC.) I want you to meet Miss JIM-enez, Eric.

MEXICAN-AMERICAN: Miss JIM-enez, delighted to make your acquaintance. (kisses her hand.)

SECRETARY: Oh, my, how charming! How about boards, does he function on boards?

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SANCHO: You name them, he is on them. Parole boards, draft boards, school boards, taco quality control boards . . .

SECRETARY: Does he function in politics?

SANCHO: Señorita, you are looking at a political machine. Have you ever heard of the WAR ON POVERTY? That's our model! Not only that, he makes political speeches.

SECRETARY: May I hear one?

SANCHO: With pleasure. (Snap.) Eric, give us a speech.

MEXICAN-AMERICAN: Mr. Congressman, Mr. Chairman, members of the board, honored guests, ladies and gentlemen. (SANCHO and SECRETARY applaud.) Please, please. I come before you as a Mexican-American to tell you about the problems of the Mexican. The problems of the Mexican stem from one thing and one thing only: he's stupid. He's uneducated. He needs to stay in school. He needs to be ambitious, foward-looking, harder-working. He needs to think American, American, American! God bless America! God bless America! God bless America! (He goes out of control. SANCHO snaps frantically and the MEXICAN-AMERICAN finally slumps forward, bending at the waist.)

SECRETARY: Oh my, he's patriotic too! What about upkeep? Is he economical?

SANCHO: Well, no, I won't lie to you. The Mexican-American costs a little bit more, but you get what you pay for. He's worth every extra cent. You can keep him running on dry Martinis, Langendorf bread …

SECRETARY: Apple pie?

SANCHO: Only Mom's. Of course, he's also programmed to eat Mexican food at ceremonial functions, but I must warn you, an overdose of beans will plug up his exhaust.

SECRETARY: How much do you want for him?

SANCHO: Well, I tell you what I'm gonna do. Today and today only, because you've been so sweet, I'm gonna let you drive him off the lot for $15,000.

SECRETARY: Fifteen thousand dollars? For a Mexican!!!!

SANCHO: Mexican? What are you talking about? This is a Mexican-American! You want quality, but you gotta pay for it! This is no cheap run-about. He's got class!

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SECRETARY: Okay, I'll take him. (Hands Sancho the $$ in cash) The Governor is having a luncheon this afternoon, and we need a brown face in the crowd. How do I drive him?

SANCHO: Just snap your fingers. He'll do anything you want. (SECRETARY snaps. MEXICAN-AMERICAN steps forward.)

MEXICAN-AMERICAN: ¡Raza querida, vamos levantando armas para liberarnos de estos desgraciados gabachos que nos explotan! (Secretary snaps and model freezes)

SECRETARY: What did he say?

SANCHO: Something about taking up arms, killing people, etc.

SECRETARY: He's not supposed to say that!

SANCHO: Look, lady, don't blame me for bugs from the factory. He's your Mexican-American, you bought him, now drive him off the lot! Try snapping another finger. (SECRETARY snaps. MEXICAN-AMERICAN comes to life again.)

MEXICAN-AMERICAN: ¡Basta! ¡Basta! ¡Viva la raza! ¡Viva la causa! ¡Viva la huelga! ¡Chicano power! (The MEXICAN-AMERICAN turns toward the SECRETARY, who gasps, backs up and runs out of the shop screaming. All freeze. After a few seconds of silence, the JOHNNY PACHUCO moves and stretches. SANCHO stays frozen to his spot.)

JOHNNY: Man, that was a long one, ese. (Others agree with him.)

FARMWORKER: (moves and stretches) How did we do?

JOHNNY: Pretty good, look at all that lana, man! (He goes over to SANCHO and removes the money from his hand. SANCHO stays where he is.) We keep this up, we're going to be rich.

FARMWORKER: They think we're machines.

REVOLUCIONARIO: (moves and stretches) Burros.

JOHNNY: Puppets.

MEXICAN-AMERICAN: The only thing I don't like is how come I always get to play the Mexican-American?

JOHNNY: That's what you get for finishing high school.

FARMWORKER: How about our wages, ese?

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JOHNNY: $3,000 for you, $3,000 for you, $3,000 for you and $3,000 for me. The rest we put back into the business. (Notices Sancho, still frozen) What about our salesman? I think he needs an oil job.

REVOLUCIONARIO: Leave him to me. (REVOLUCIONARIO goes over to SANCHO, removes his hat, lifts him up and throws him over his shoulder. SANCHO hangs loose, lifeless. To audience.) He's the best model we got! ¡Ajúa!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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CUTTING STORED IN THE VAULT: [Found in Luis Valdez Early Works, pg 40-52] Through the use of satire and humor the author shows the prejudice faced by Chicanos as he depicts a secretary from the Governor's office who has come to buy a Mexican American from Honest Sancho's Used Mexican Shop for token integration of his administration. Several "types" are interviewed and rejected.

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